

meant that centralization no longer matters; what corporate America's fervor for downsizing and decentralization is saying is that very large companies no longer have an advantage.

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Modern computer technology puts small companies in the big league.

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Cheap computers and communications have made bank automatic teller machines possible. Most of us like to do business with an ATM rather than a bank teller, because the ATM is in a convenient location, is available twenty-four hours a day, is accurate and confidential, and doesn't make you stand in line. The ATM has also been a tremendous boon to banks. Banks that wanted to gain deposits and generate business around the city used to have to open a network of branches. Dozens of small offices were expensive to run. Today, most of that banking can be done with an ATM machine stuck in a gas station, a grocery store, or a street kiosk. Not having to lay out for bricks and mortar has allowed banks to close many of their neighborhood branches and still serve their customers, which has translated into higher earnings. In addition, when a bank is just a node in the computer network system that issues your ATM card and your credit card, bank mergers make logical sense; banks are acquired at generous prices. We have owned the shares of banks in Salt Lake City, Seattle, Memphis, and Honolulu.

The slot machine and the ATM are quite similar microcomputers under the skin. If you like, you can think of the ATM as a slot machine with a boring payoff. Alternatively, the slot machine can be considered the ultimate user-friendly computer. (Not so friendly, I admit, once your money runs out.) A growing percentage of casino gamblers prefer the machines to dealing with humans at table